[..] Neither magic nor modern technology were among the things she could learn much about during her childhood.

As she read through the various advertisements, she noticed a large object within the corner of her eye, on the other side of the metal road. As she turned to face it, she saw the airship that brought her to the station; flying off into a destination unknown to her.

“They must be on their way to other villages, like mine” She thought, as she pondered the ship crew’s direction. This caused the words of the supervisor to echo in her mind, which quickly made her worry.

“Other students were supposed to arrive here as well, but I have not seen anyone yet. Are they lost, or is it that I was brought to the wrong station?”

She became deathly pale, as the idea of being completely on her own in this utterly alien place, creeped into her mind.

She fought to dispel the visions of begging in the streets, or facing a fate far worse, as she heard footsteps.

The sound was coming from the stairway leading into the station.

She turned to face the person climbing the stairs, trying to catch a glimpse of the new arrival.

A moment had passed and soon a girl, about the same age as Perphena, came into view. As she climbed the stairs Perphena analysed her appearance.

The girl wore the same academy uniform, with a notable exception of an almost comically large pointed black hat with a large, circular brim.

The hat was large enough that if the girl were to pull it down, it could cover her entire face and, as a matter of fact, it was already covering most of it.

As she finally stepped onto the station, she paused for a moment to catch a breath then lifted the brim of her hat to reveal a pair of turquoise eyes, creeping from beyond large circular glasses. In their frames was trapped a lock of ginger-gold hair, which seemingly evaded being tied into low pigtails.
In addition to the standard leather bag they both carried, the girl also had a second one; entirely black and when placed on the ground, taller than she was.
Its size immediately explained the girl's tiredness.

The girl looked around the station and upon seeing no one except for Perphena, her face took on a worried expression.
"No way!" She exclaimed. "Did I miss it? I wasn't told at which hour the {Vehicle that travels the Nether veins} takes off!"
She clearly looked up to Perphena for explanation, but she had none to give.
"I-I was just brought here a while ago. If you missed it, then I guess we both did?"
She replied with a nervous smile.
Hearing that, the girl exhaled, as if a great burden was just lifted off her shoulders.
"I'm so glad. I was worried that I missed the ride completely. I took a few wrong turns along the way."
She walked up to the metal fence, and looked out in both directions. She turned around, and surveyed the station, only to lock her gaze back onto Perphena.
"Where is everyone? I was told that other students should be waiting at the station."
Perphena shrugged, not knowing herself whether more students will ever show up at the station, or if both of them counted as "other students". "I-I was told the same thing."

Hearing that, the girl turned pale.

“What if… we’re both at the wrong station?”

Perphena became visibly more worried, as she considered such a possibility. As she thought back about her travels, she did notice that her supervisor did not exude an aura of professionalism.

In response, the girl in front of her looked even more panicked.

“We have to find someone, and ask if there are any other stations in here!”

She rushed towards the stair, then stopped as if pulled by a rope, right before the first step.

“Wait, someone has to stay here. In case this IS the right spot!”

“So, which one should stay?”

Both of the girls appeared, as if they were deeply absorbed in their thoughts. After a brief moment, Perphena suggested the next move.

“How about rock paper scissors? I played that once”

“Oh! That will work.”

Perphena moved closer and they both raised their fists, ready to leave the choice to fate, when they were interrupted by a deep growling noise. They stopped with their fists mid-fall, and both realised the source of the noise.

Neither of them ate anything since they woke up.

“Yeah… it seems that’s going to have to wait.” The girl said with a pained expression. And started a slow trek down the stairs. “First, we have to find something to eat”

The hunger clearly wiped the fear off of their minds.

Perphena looked around the station once more, and spotted an object that was previously not visible from when she was standing.

It was a rectangular metal box, with a big glass window, and an assortment of buttons. Fortunately, the machine seemed to glow with internal light, so one could easily peer inside. Behind the window, she could see what seemed like sandwiches, cakes and other items she could not name, yet could still recognise as food.

She called out to her famished companion.

“What about this thing? It seems like there is something to eat here” Perphena pointed her finger in the direction of the strange contraption.

The girl’s pointy hat shot out from the stairway like an arrow, and her gaze quickly turned into the direction where Perphena was pointing.

“We’re saved!” She explained in excitement, and both of them approached the machine.

Once in front, both of them were amazed to see that it does indeed hold food inside. However, they encountered a rather difficult problem. They had no idea how to take it out.

The villages in which they had spent their entire lives up to this point, were still not reached by technological progress brought about by the new age.

“Let’s see” The girl said while stroking her chin, and scrutinising the mechanisms behind the glass panel. “It is as I thought”

“You know what this is?”

“Not a faintest clue”

“That doesn’t seem very helpful.” Perphena thought to herself, before deciding against sharing the comment.

“I know”, the girl said, as she pulled out a large book out of her leather bag and began flipping through the pages.

Perphena walked behind her, to peer inside, making use of the girl’s lack of

awareness. Despite the obstruction of the girl's giant hat, she could see what seemed like pictures, and description of many modern devices she saw along the way to the station.

Her desire to study the book herself was growing with each passing page.

"T-the guide doesn't seem to mention it", the girl moaned out, while flipping the pages faster and faster.

Perphena stepped away from her companion, and investigated the face of the machine. Upon closer look, she noticed a slit in the machine's frame, right next to an assortment of buttons. The buttons were numbered, and the items behind the window seemed to have numbers below the spiral shelves upon which they lay. She quickly put the two and two together, and came to the conclusion.

"Look, I think we have to pick a number, and insert something"

"Hmm, like what? Coins?"

The two girls paused for a moment, then opened up their bags, only to see that they contained nothing more than their personal items.

"I spent everything on the book yesterday."

"I never had anything to begin with."

They stepped away from the machine, with sour expressions, ready to give up. Then suddenly, they heard the deafening noise of their rumbling stomachs.

"I guess these are critical circumstances", said Perphena, and approached the machine once more.

She crouched in front of it, and tried to move her hand through the trapdoor at the bottom, which was used to receive the paid-for goods.

She reached inside and up, but she could not reach anything, even on the lowest shelves.

“Hey, we can’t just steal it!” The girl voiced her objection. Although, her eyes seemed to say: “come on, you can do it!”.

Perphena pulled out her arm, with nothing to show, and noticed a disappointed look on her companion's face.

Having exhausted conventional options, she decided to resort to unconventional measures.

She pointed her hand at the floor right next to the trapdoor, and focused.

Shadows began swirling and growing at the spot and she halted her efforts to look at the girl next to her, expecting a harsh admonition. A reflex, developed over long years.

Doing those sorts of things never ended well for her. Her talents were always met with scorn, from those who as much as caught a glimpse.

She looked over at the girl standing nearby, not knowing what kind of reaction to expect.

Her companion, however, looked on with visible excitement.

“This is different” She thought, as she felt a rush of joy. She turned back towards the machine, and fended off the smile, which tried to encroach upon her cheeks.

With regained focus, she concentrated on the shadow once more.

In a moment’s notice, a vaguely humanoid creature emerged from the darkness.

The shadow creature pushed on the tray’s door, and pushed its bulbous body into the machine.

“Woah, that’s so cool” the girl whispered.

“So, what do you want?” A rogueish smile showed up on Perphena’s face, despite her valiant efforts.

“W-wait no!” The girl shook her head “That’s uhm… we can’t do that”

“You’d rather be hungry?”

The question seemed to prevent any further objections. And the girl replied after a while.

“T-the, the egg salad sandwich…”

The creature climbed on the shelves of the machine, knocking down many additional objects, such as juice cartons, and beverage cans.

It didn’t take long before Perphena could open the trap door, and pick up the items lying on the bottom.

“See, it was easy. And no one will know.”

Just as she said that, the machine made a loud continuous noise, as if someone was furiously shaking a bell.

Perphena immediately started packing the food into the bag, while her partner in crime looked around with a panicked gaze.

Having stuffed her bag full of food, she grabbed the girl by the cloak.

“Hurry, we need to get out!”

But before they could move from the place. They heard loud steps from the tunnel leading into the station, indicating that someone was approaching their location, at a very fast pace.

This time, it was Perphena’s turn to panic.

She began writing down lines and lines of apologies within her head, addressed to whomever is heading their way.

Suddenly, she looked over to her companion, who was now unzipping her massive black bag. Inside it there was a broom. “A poor excuse for a weapon”, the girl thought, before she realised something. It did not look like any ordinary broom. bristles were of a very soft, fur-like material, and were split into one large, and two smaller brushes, in reddish-orange colours. The brushes were tied with grey-blue ropes, and although the polished wood handle of the broom was as thin as in any other, the part which connected to the brushes was much thicker.
It was covered in brown leather, and before the broom was even out of the bag, she had realised.
“It’s a seat…”

An old man ran up the stairs and to the vending machine. He looked around a few times, before finally appearing next to it. He pulled out a key from the pocket in his pants, then opened the panel behind the machine. With a flip of a switch, the machine fell silent.
The man crouched down, and inspected another of the machine’s panels.
“Damned thieves” He cursed under his breath after a while. “How in the nether did they even do it?”
He closed the machine, and as he made his way back, he did not notice the two children’s heads that observed him from above the edge of the roof shielding the station from the sun and rain.

“That was close” said Perphena
“Too close for my liking.”

Perphena opened her bag, and pulled out the snacks, snatched from the vending machine.

Most of them were covered in a see-through material that at first evoked an image of glass. The material, however, was too soft for that to be the case.

The girl took off her pointy hat, and grabbed onto the egg salad sandwich. Both of them stared at the unfamiliar packaging for a while, before she ripped it open.

“Oh! I know what this is.” The girl said while stuffing the sandwich into her mouth. She held the food in her teeth, while using both hands to pull out the book from her bag.

She started to flip through the pages, while trying to talk, with the meal still held with her mouth.

“Aw thinth, ith called pthlasthic!”

“Uh, I can’t understand you with food still in your mouth, uhm…”

“Oh shorry.” The girl rested the book on her thighs, to grab the sandwich, and having done that, swallowed the food. “Sorry about that, my name is Sybilla.” She wiped her right hand against her skirt, and handed it to Perphena

“Perphena!” She replied, and shook the girl’s hand.

Sybilla moved closer to her, so that both of them had a good view of the book.

“I think it's called plastic.” She opened the appropriate portion of her book. “It’s made of a type of oil”

“Oil? I’ve never heard of it” Perphena said, feeling a bit embarrassed for her lack of knowledge.

Sybilla smiled and started flicking through the pages in her book.

“I think it’s on page 65, hold on, I’ll find it.”